

Defining Culture

Culture is the complex system of meaning and behavior that defines the way of life for a given group or society. It includes beliefs, values, knowledge, art, morals, laws, customs, habits, language, and dress, among other things. Culture includes ways of thinking as well as patterns of behavior. Observing culture involves studying what people think, how they interact, and the objects they use.

In any society, culture defines what is perceived as beautiful and ugly, right and wrong, good and bad. Culture helps hold society together, giving people a sense of belonging, instructing them on how to behave, and telling them what to think in particular situations. Culture gives meaning to society.

Material Culture

Material culture *consists of human technology—all the things human beings make and use, from small, hand-held tools to skyscrapers.* Without material culture, our species could not survive long because material culture provides a buffer between humans and their environment. Using it, human beings can protect themselves from environmental stresses, as when they build shelters and wear clothing to protect themselves from the cold or from strong sunlight.

Even more important, humans use material culture to modify and exploit the environment. They build dams and irrigation canals, plant fields and forests, convert coal and oil into energy, and transform ores into versatile metals. Using material culture, our species has learned to cope with the most extreme environments and to survive and even to thrive on all continents and in all climates.

Nonmaterial Culture

Every society also has a **nonmaterial culture**, which consists of *the totality of knowledge, beliefs, values, and rules for appropriate behavior*. The nonmaterial culture is structured by such institutions as the family, religion, education, economy, and government.

Whereas material culture is made up of things that have a physical existence (they can be seen, touched, and so on), *the elements of nonmaterial culture are the ideas associated with their use*. Although engagement rings

The Elements of Culture

Culture is multifaceted, consisting of both material and nonmaterial things, some parts of culture being abstract, others more concrete. The different elements of culture include language, norms, beliefs, and values (see Table 2.1).

Language

Language is a set of symbols and rules that, combined in a meaningful way, provides a complex communication system. The formation of culture among humans is made possible by language. Learning the language of a culture is essential to becoming part of a society, and it is one of the first things children learn. Indeed,



Norms are *the rules of behavior that are agreed upon and shared within a culture and that prescribe limits of acceptable behavior.* They define normal expected behavior and help people achieve predictability in their lives. **For example,** one of the few truly universal gestures is the kiss.



Mores (pronounced more-ays) are *strongly held norms that usually have a moral connotation and are based on the central values of the culture.* Violations of mores

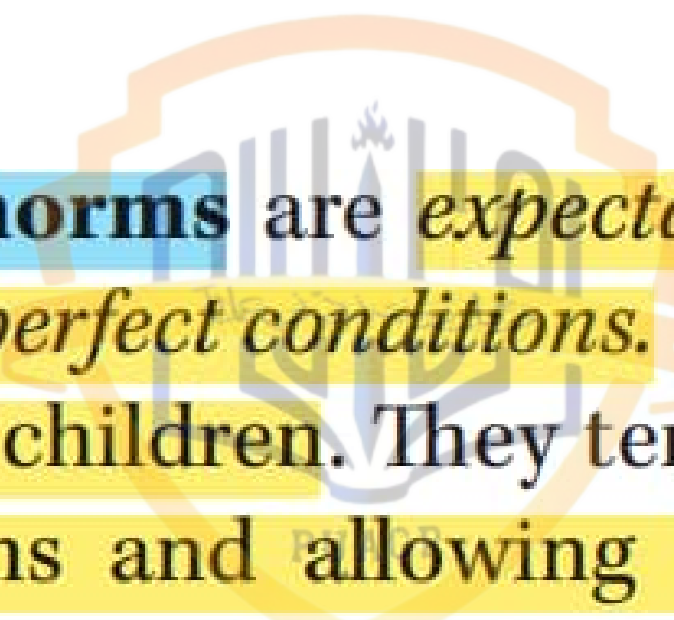
produce strong negative reactions, which are often supported by law. Desecration of a church or temple, sexual molestation of a child, rape, murder, incest, and child beating are all violations of American mores.

Not all norms command such absolute conformity. Much of day-to-day life is governed by traditions, or **folkways**, which are *norms that permit a wide degree of individual interpretation as long as certain limits are not overstepped*. People who violate folkways are seen as peculiar or possibly eccentric, but rarely do they elicit strong public response.

Good manners in our culture also show a range of acceptable behavior. A man might or might not open a door or hold a coat for a woman, who might also choose to open a door or hold a coat for a man—all four options are acceptable behavior and cause neither comment nor negative reactions from people.

These two examples illustrate another aspect of folkways: They change with time. Not too long ago, a man was *always* expected to hold a door open for a woman, and a woman was *never* expected to hold a coat for a man.

Folkways also vary from one culture to another. In



Ideal norms are *expectations of what people should do under perfect conditions*. These are the norms we first teach our children. They tend to be simple, making few distinctions and allowing for no exceptions. In reality, however, nothing about human beings is ever that dependable.

Real norms are *norms that are expressed with qualifications and allowances for differences in individual*

behavior. They specify how people actually behave. They reflect the fact that a person's behavior is guided by norms as well as unique situations.

In Kazakhstan, for example, although bribery is frowned upon, professors are so poorly paid that, over the years, a norm system has developed in which they supplement their salaries by taking money or other items from their students in return for higher grades. The cultural

Values

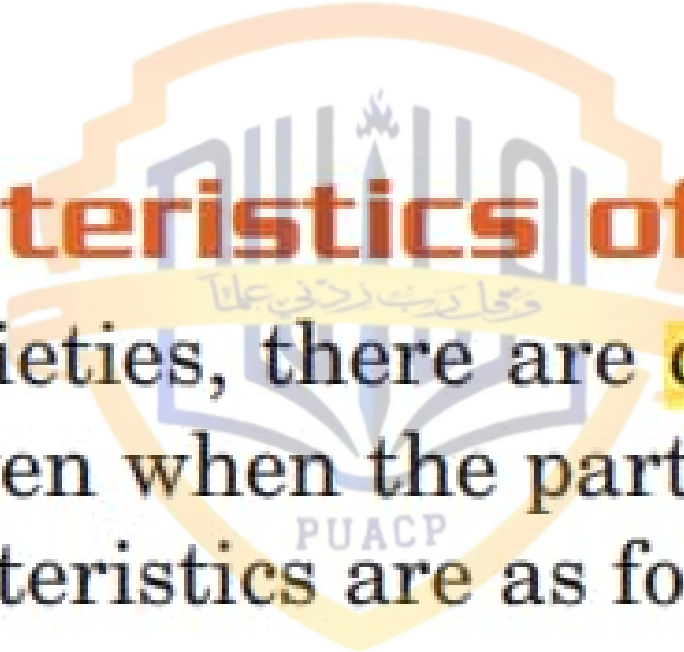
Deeply intertwined with beliefs are the values of a culture. **Values** are the abstract standards in a society or group that define ideal principles. Values define what is desirable and morally correct; thus, values determine what is considered right and wrong, beautiful and ugly, good and bad. Although values are abstract, they provide a general outline for behavior. Freedom, for example, is a value held to be important in U.S. culture, as is equality. Values are ideals



Values are *a culture's general orientations toward life—its notions of what is good and bad, what is desirable and undesirable.* For example, each year, the University

table2.1**Elements of Culture**

	Definition	Examples
Language	A set of symbols and rules that, put together in a meaningful way, provides a complex communication system	English; Spanish; hieroglyphics
Norms	The specific cultural expectations for how to behave in a given situation	Behavior involving use of personal space; manners
Folkways	General standards of behavior adhered to by a group	Cultural forms of dress; food habits
Mores	Strict norms that control moral and ethical behavior	Religious doctrines; formal law
Values	Abstract standards in a society or group that define ideal principles	Liberty; freedom
Beliefs	Shared ideas about what is true held collectively by people within a given culture	Belief in a higher being

The logo of the Punjab University of Agriculture, Chakralar (PUACP) is centered in the background. It features a shield-like emblem with a book and a torch, surrounded by Urdu text and the acronym PUACP.

Characteristics of Culture

Across societies, there are common characteristics of culture, even when the particulars vary. These different characteristics are as follows.

1. ***Culture is shared.*** Culture would have no significance if people did not hold it in common. Culture is collectively experienced and collectively agreed

2. *Culture is learned.* Cultural beliefs and practices are usually so well learned that they seem perfectly natural, but they are learned none the less. How do people come to prefer some foods to others? How is musical taste acquired? Culture may be taught through direct instruction, such as a parent teaching a child how to use silverware or teachers instructing children in songs, myths, and other traditions in school.

4. ***Culture is symbolic.*** The significance of culture lies in the meaning it holds for people. **Symbols** are things or behaviors to which people give meaning; the meaning is not inherent in a symbol but is bestowed by the meaning people give it. The U.S. flag, for example, is literally a decorated piece of cloth. Its cultural significance derives not from the cloth of which it is made but from its meaning as a symbol of freedom and democracy, as was witnessed by the widespread



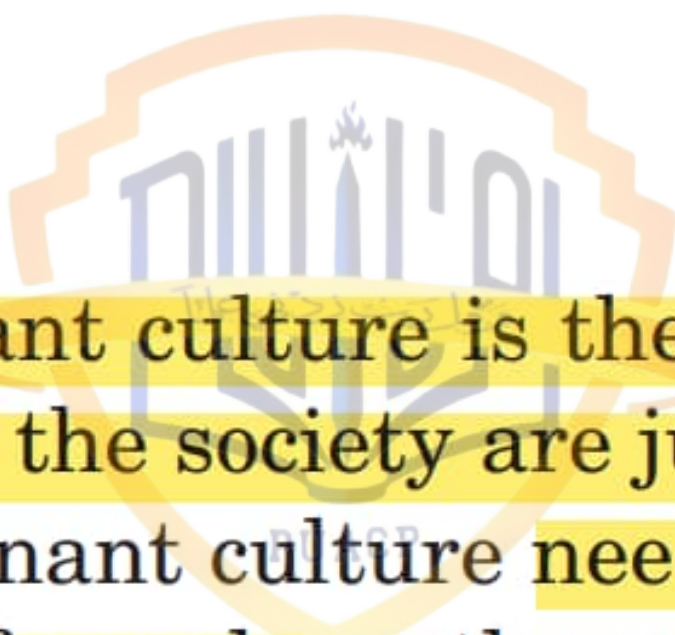
5. ***Culture varies across time and place.*** Culture develops as humans adapt to the physical and social environment around them. Culture is not fixed from one place to another. In the United States,

Cultural Diversity

It is rare for a society to be culturally uniform. As societies develop and become more complex, different cultural traditions appear. The more complex the society, the more likely its culture will be internally varied and diverse. The United States, for example, hosts enormous cultural diversity stemming from religious, ethnic, and racial differences, as well as regional, age, gender, and class differences. Currently, more

Dominant Culture

Two concepts from sociology help us understand the complexity of culture in a given society: dominant culture and subculture. The **dominant culture** is the culture of the most powerful group in a society. It is the cultural form that receives the most support from major institutions and that constitutes the major belief system. Although the dominant culture is not the only culture in a society, it is commonly believed to be “the” culture of a society despite the other cultures



the dominant culture is the standard by which other cultures in the society are judged.

A dominant culture need not be the culture of the majority of people; rather, it is simply the culture of that group in society with enough power to define the cultural framework. As an example, think of a college

Subcultures

Subcultures are the cultures of groups whose values and norms of behavior differ to some degree from those of the dominant culture. Members of subcultures tend to interact frequently with one another and share a common worldview. They may be identifiable by their appearance (style of clothing or adornments) or perhaps by language, dialect, or other cultural markers. You can



Sociologists use the term **subculture** to refer to *the distinctive lifestyles, values, norms, and beliefs of certain segments of the population within a society.*

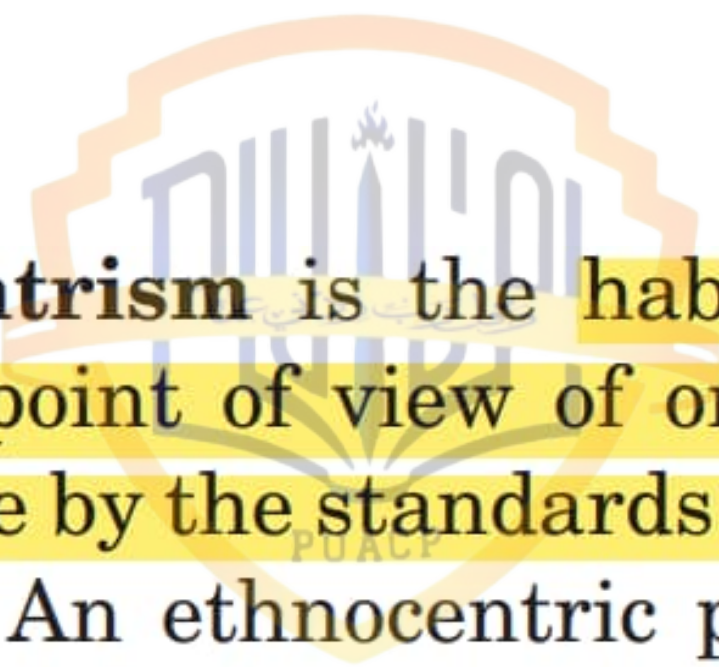
Types of Subcultures

Several groups have been studied at one time or another by sociologists as examples of subcultures. These can be classified roughly as follows.

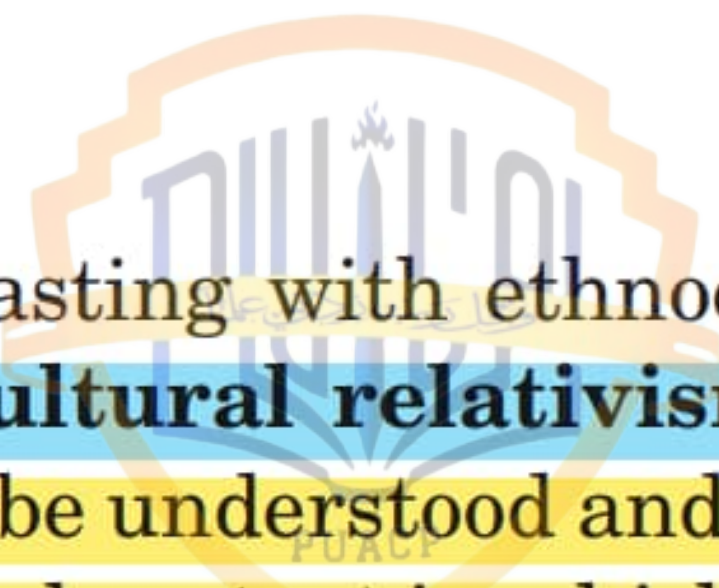
- Ethnic
- Social Class
- Occupational
- Religious
- Political
- Geographical
- Deviant [In clash with others]

Countercultures

Countercultures are subcultures created as a reaction against the values of the dominant culture. Members of the counterculture reject the dominant cultural values, often for political or moral reasons, and develop cultural practices that explicitly defy the norms and values of the dominant group. Nonconformity to the dominant culture is often the hallmark of a counterculture. Youth groups often form countercultures. Why? In part, they



Ethnocentrism is the habit of seeing things only from the point of view of one's own group. Judging one culture by the standards of another culture is ethnocentric. An ethnocentric perspective prevents you from understanding the world as it is experienced by others, and it can lead to narrow-minded conclusions about the worth of diverse cultures.

The logo of the University of Al-Qadisiyah is a circular emblem. It features a central minaret with a flame-like top, surrounded by Arabic calligraphy. The emblem is set against a background of a gear-like border.

Contrasting with ethnocentrism is cultural relativism. **Cultural relativism** is the idea that something can be understood and judged only in relation to the cultural context in which it appears. This does not make every cultural practice morally acceptable, but it suggests that without knowing the cultural context, it is impossible to understand why people behave as

as conflict theorists would argue. The diffusion of a single culture throughout the world is referred to as **global culture**. Despite the enormous diversity of cultures worldwide, fashion, food, entertainment, and other cultural values are increasingly dominated by U.S. markets, thereby creating a more homogenous world culture. Global culture is increasingly marked by capitalist interests, squeezing out the more diverse folk cultures that have been common throughout the world (Rieff 1993).

table 2.3***Theoretical Perspectives on Culture***

	According to:		
Functionalism	Conflict Theory	Symbolic Interaction	New Cultural Studies
Culture . . .			
Integrates people into groups	Serves the interests of powerful groups	Creates group identity from diverse cultural meanings	Is ephemeral, unpredictable, and constantly changing
Provides coherence and stability in society	Can be a source of political resistance	Changes as people produce new cultural meanings	Is a material manifestation of a consumer-oriented society
Creates norms and values that integrate people in society	Is increasingly controlled by economic monopolies	Is socially constructed through the activities of social groups	Is best understood by analyzing its artifacts—books, films, television images

- ***What is culture?***

Culture is the complex and elaborate system of meaning and behavior that defines the way of life for a group or society. It is shared, learned, taken for granted, symbolic, and emergent and varies from one society to another.

- ***How do sociologists define norms, beliefs, and values?***

Norms are rules of social behavior that guide every situation and may be formal or informal. When norms are violated, social sanctions are applied. *Beliefs* are strongly shared ideas about the nature of social reality. *Values* are the abstract concepts in

a society that define the worth of different things and ideas.

- ***What is the significance of diversity in human cultures?***

As societies develop and become more complex, cultural diversity can appear. The United States is highly diverse culturally, with many of its traditions influenced by immigrant cultures and the cultures of African Americans, Latinos, and Native Americans. The *dominant culture* is the culture of the most powerful group in society. *Subcultures* are groups whose *values* and cultural patterns depart significantly from the *dominant culture*.

- ***What is the sociological significance of the mass media and popular culture?***

Elements of popular culture, such as the *mass media*, have an enormous influence on groups' beliefs and values, including images associated with racism and sexism. *Popular culture* includes the beliefs, practices, and objects of everyday traditions.

- ***What do different sociological theories reveal about culture?***

Sociological theory provides different perspectives on the significance of culture. *Functionalist theory* emphasizes the influence of values, norms, and beliefs on the whole society. *Conflict theorists* see

culture as influenced by economic interests and power relations in society. *Symbolic interactionists* emphasize that culture is socially constructed. This has influenced new cultural studies, which interpret culture as a series of images that can be analyzed from the viewpoint of different observers.

How do cultures change?

There are several sources of cultural change, including change in societal conditions, *cultural diffusion*, innovation, and the imposition of change by dominant groups. As cultures change, *culture lag* can result, meaning that sometimes cultural adjustments are out of synchrony with each other. Persons who experience new cultural situations may experience *culture shock*.